

Semi-Secret Wars

Game Design Document (GDD)

Version: 0.2

Status: Living Document

1. Game Overview

Title

Semi-Secret Wars

Genre

Roguelite Auto-Battler — run-based, chained fixed levels, permadeath within a run.

Engine

Godot 4.7-stable, GL Compatibility

Target Platform

PC, 1920×1080 fullscreen

Project Status

Vertical slice — 3 levels, 4 heroes, full run loop playable end-to-end and Designer-verified.

2. High Concept

Semi-Secret Wars is a minimalist roguelite auto-battler presented as the pages of a child's comic notebook. A **run**, not a single battle, is the unit of play: the player drafts a party once, then chains through a series of fixed, authored levels — carrying HP, in-run levels, and boons forward — until the party wipes. A loss sends the player back to Level 1. What persists between runs is **knowledge** (a permanent, fog-revealed map of each level) and **gold** (permanent ability upgrades).

3. Design Pillars

- The run, not the battle, is the unit of play
 - Knowledge as progression — mastering a fixed, fog-revealed map
 - One meaningful in-battle lever (focus ping), otherwise fully automated combat
 - Permanent, low-friction meta-growth (gold-bought ability mods)
 - Simple, charming notebook presentation
 - Real attrition — the dead stay dead within a run
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4. Target Experience

The player should feel that:

- Every run leans on what was learned and unlocked in the last one.
 - A wipe is a fresh attempt, not a reset to zero — the map and the gold-bought kit persist.
 - Strategy happens at prep (party draft, mod purchases); combat itself is decisive and automatic.
 - The one command they have — focus ping — matters when they use it.
 - Losing a hero mid-run has real weight; there is no revive.
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5. Gameplay Loop

Prep (once per run)

- Draft a 3-of-4 party.
- Spend gold on permanent ability mods.

Per level

- Deploy the party on a fixed field. Fog persists — a level explored on an earlier run stays revealed forever.
 - Heroes fight automatically: escalating swarm from authored gates, hazards, objective markers for XP; heroes level up in-run via 1-of-3 boon picks.
 - The player has one command verb — a limited-charge **focus ping** — to bias where the party commits.
 - The villain sits dormant at a learnable lair until the party closes in, then fights in its own style.
 - Win (villain down) chains straight into the next level, carrying HP/boons/levels; the dead stay dead. A wipe ends the run, awards gold (scaled by levels cleared), and returns to prep at Level 1.
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6. Visual Direction

Art Style

- Minimalist, hand-drawn
- Notebook aesthetic, child's comic book
- Simple colors, thick outlines, imperfect shapes

The game takes place inside the pages of a child's notebook. Terrain and obstacles render with a hand-inked, cross-hatched style; heroes and minions use real sprites (Thundaar, Minion) with placeholder art for the rest.

Animation Style

Inspired by South Park, paper puppets, and children's doodles. Animations use body bobbing, small rotations, simple scaling, and limited keyframes — personality over realism.

7. Heroes

Roster (4, draft 3-of-4 per run): **Thundaar** (Tank — Stomp AoE/knockback), **Artemis** (Burst — Clone taunting stand-in), **WARDEN** (Control — Ensnare roots a cluster), **BEACON** (Support — Rally damage + attack-speed buff).

Every hero has its full ability kit from run start (abilities are intrinsic, not unlocked). Growth comes from two sources: in-run boons (reset each run, picked 1-of-3 on level-up) and permanent gold-bought ability mods (owned forever, bought at prep). The 8 ability mods are currently upside-only — their designed downsides are disabled in code while Level 1 tuning is the focus (2026-07-18).

8. Villains

One villain per level, each sitting dormant at a fixed lair until a hero closes in or lands a hit:

- Level 1 — Dark Mage: teleport/resummon, leashed to its lair so a chasing party's progress isn't reset by the old un-catchable flee.
 - Level 2 — Berserker: charge/recover aggression pattern.
 - Level 3 — Mech Robot: stationary, periodic slow-zone AoE.
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9. Minions

Swarms pour from authored, fixed gates per level (escalating throughput/caps). They hunt the nearest hero field-wide, steer to intercept the hero's route, and exist to delay progression and protect the villain.

10. Battlefields / Levels

Three authored levels (Levels 1–3), each a fixed layout (not randomized): obstacles, lakes, objectives, scenery, the villain lair, and minion gates, defined in `config/level\_layout.gd` resources. Fog of war persists per level to disk — explored ground stays revealed forever across runs, making the map itself a form of permanent progression.

11. Objectives & Hero Priorities

Before a run, the player assigns each hero a battlefield priority:

- Attack Minions — engage nearby enemies, advance when clear
 - Capture Objectives — hold until captured (commits once spotted), then advance
 - Attack Villain — push toward the villain, fight only what blocks the path
 - Support Allies — default for Support-role heroes
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12. Combat

Fully automated open-field movement with obstacle avoidance. Minions attempt to intercept; heroes pursue their assigned priority toward objectives/villain. The player's only live input is the **focus ping** — 3

charges, a dropped marker that heroes converge on for 5s and that biases target selection toward enemies near it; a charge refunds on objective capture. Locking onto an alerted villain makes the ping track his live position.

13. Progression

Two currencies, two horizons:

- XP (in-run only): kills + objective captures feed each hero's in-run level. On level-up, pick 1 of 3 boons (Power/Vitality/Haste/Swiftness/Fortune/Ferocity). Boons reset every run but carry across levels within a run. Levels 0–2 cost half XP so the first picks land fast.
- Gold (permanent): awarded at run end, scaled by levels cleared. Spent at prep on permanent per-hero ability mods — bought once, owned forever.

The deepest progression is **knowledge**: fixed levels plus persistent fog mean the player learns each map — gate positions, the lair, hazards, objective spots — and every run leans on what they've already mapped and unlocked.

14. Game Economy

Rewards: XP (kills + objective capture) feeds in-run boons; gold (awarded at run end) buys permanent ability mods; map knowledge (persistent fog) is earned simply by surviving further into a level. See `BALANCE.md` for exact economy values.

15. Balance Philosophy

The game should reward persistence and map mastery rather than luck. A loss should feel like a fresh, better-armed attempt — not a reset to zero — because the fog map and the gold-bought kit both persist. Balance values remain configurable and are tracked in `BALANCE.md` rather than hardcoded.

16. Audio

Music: TBD. Sound Effects: TBD. Voice Acting: TBD. See `AUDIO_BIBLE.md`.

17. Narrative

Story: TBD. Setting: a child's notebook. No narrative content implemented yet — the notebook framing is purely visual/tonal so far.

18. Localization & Accessibility

Both TBD — see `LOCALIZATION.md`. Player-facing text should eventually use localization keys.

19. Known TBDs

- Exact combat formulas & damage calculations
 - Full ability-mod tradeoff rebalance (downsides currently disabled)
 - Level 2/3 balance pass (still on stale pre-rework numbers)
 - Value-proposition playtest (does replaying a mapped level feel like mastery?)
 - Between-level heal/revive (deliberately deferred)
 - Partner-pairing deploy rule
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Revision History

Version	Date	Notes
0.1	2026-07-13	Initial design document (all TBD)
0.2	2026-07-18	Full rewrite: run-chain roguelite rework, 4-hero roster, 3 authored levels, ability-mod economy